

THE CURIOSITY SERIES · ARTICLE V · filed by Akshat Verma

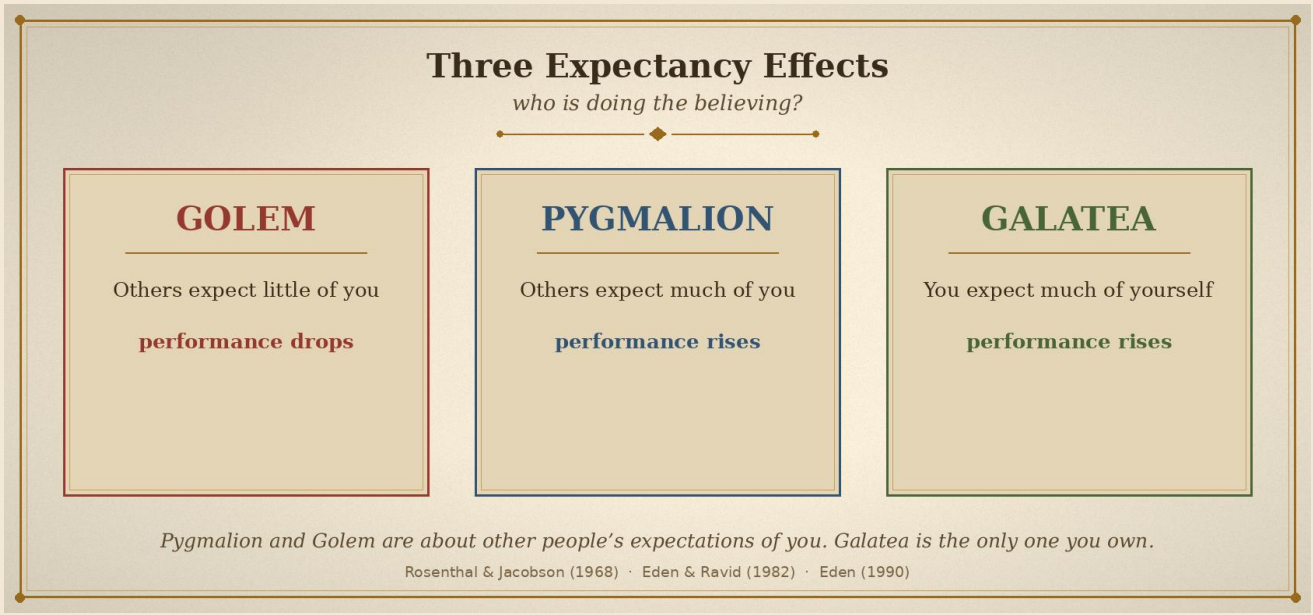
THE QUESTION

"Believe in yourself" is the most repeated advice on earth and the least examined. It is also, awkwardly, one sentence away from the manifestation claims this series has already taken apart. So: is there real science beneath self-belief, or is it a poster? The answer is yes — with a mechanism, a number, and a failure mode that no motivational post will tell you about.

BY THE NUMBERS

r = .38	21,616	1982
self-efficacy ↔ job performance, across 114 studies	*workers pooled in that meta-analysis*	*the year self-belief was first tested against a teacher's*

I THREE EFFECTS, ONE OWNER



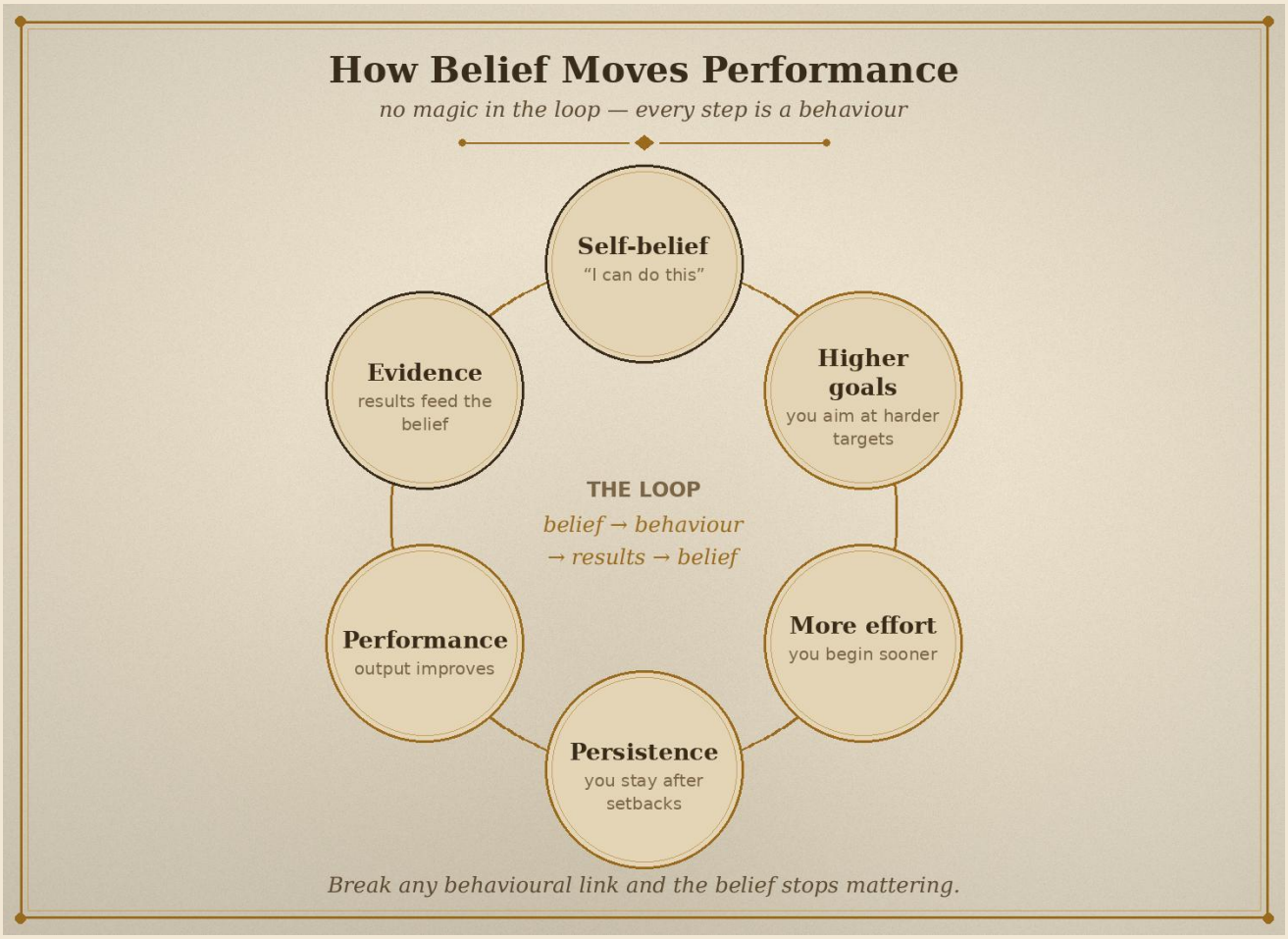
In 1968 Rosenthal and Jacobson showed that a teacher's expectations could move a student's results — the **Pygmalion effect**. Its shadow is the **Golem effect**: low expectations from others drag performance down. In 1982, Dov Eden and Gad Ravid asked the obvious next question. What if the expectation is your

own? They set instructor-expectancy against *self*-expectancy on trainee performance, and found the trainee's own expectation moved the needle too. Eden named it the **Galatea effect** in 1990. Two of these are done to you. Only one is yours.

II THE EVIDENCE

Underneath sits Albert Bandura's **self-efficacy** (1977): your belief that you can execute a specific task. It is among the most robustly supported constructs in psychology. Stajkovic and Luthans pooled 114 studies covering 21,616 workers and found a weighted correlation of **r = .38** between self-efficacy and work performance — substantial by the standards of behavioural science. And it is not only correlation: Eden and Kinnar raised self-efficacy experimentally in 1991 and increased real-world volunteering.

III THE MECHANISM



This is where self-belief parts company with manifestation. Belief does not reach out and rearrange the world. It changes *you*, and you change the world. Higher self-efficacy makes you pick harder goals, begin sooner, work longer, and — the decisive one — stay in the game after a setback instead of concluding you are not built for it. Performance rises, results become evidence, and the evidence feeds the belief. Every link in that chain is a behaviour. Break one and the belief stops mattering.

IV HOW IT IS ACTUALLY BUILT



Bandura identified four sources, and their ranking is the useful part. **Mastery experiences** — doing the thing and succeeding — are by far the strongest. Watching people like you succeed comes next. Being told you can do it is weak and fades quickly. So the practical implication is deeply unglamorous: you cannot affirm your way into self-belief. You build it out of small real wins, which is precisely why breaking a large goal into achievable pieces works.

V THE CATCH NOBODY POSTS

Belief can also make you worse. In 2002 Vancouver and colleagues found that *within* a single person, higher self-efficacy predicted **worse** performance the next time round: feeling you have it handled, you quietly allocate less effort. Bandura and Locke answered in 2003, citing nine meta-analyses. Later work points to the resolution — calibration. Moores and Chang found the relationship runs positive for the under-confident and negative for the overconfident. So: across people, belief predicts performance. Inside one person, belief that outruns the evidence turns into complacency — the same shape as the finding that vividly fantasising about success lowers effort.

VI THE VERDICT

Self-belief is the engine, not the vehicle. It works by making you act — aim higher, begin earlier, get back up. It stops working the moment it replaces the acting. The version that holds is belief kept in contact with feedback: high enough to make you begin, honest enough to keep you working.

Sources: Eden, D. & Ravid, G. (1982), "Pygmalion vs. self-expectancy," Organizational Behavior and Human Performance 30, 351–364; Eden, D. (1990) — coins "Galatea effect"; Eden, D. & Kinnar, J. (1991), "Modeling Galatea," J. Applied Psychology 76, 770–780. Bandura, A. (1977), Psychological Review 84(2), 191–215. Stajkovic, A. & Luthans, F. (1998), Psychological Bulletin 124(2), 240–261 — 114 studies, N = 21,616, r = .38. Rosenthal, R. & Jacobson, L. (1968). Counter-evidence: Vancouver, J., Thompson, C., Tischner, E. & Putka, D. (2002), J. Applied Psychology 87(3), 506–516; Bandura, A. & Locke, E. (2003); Moores, T. & Chang, J. (2009) on overconfidence. All diagrams original; concepts are standard.

Next — Article VI. Seen a claim worth checking? Send it to me.